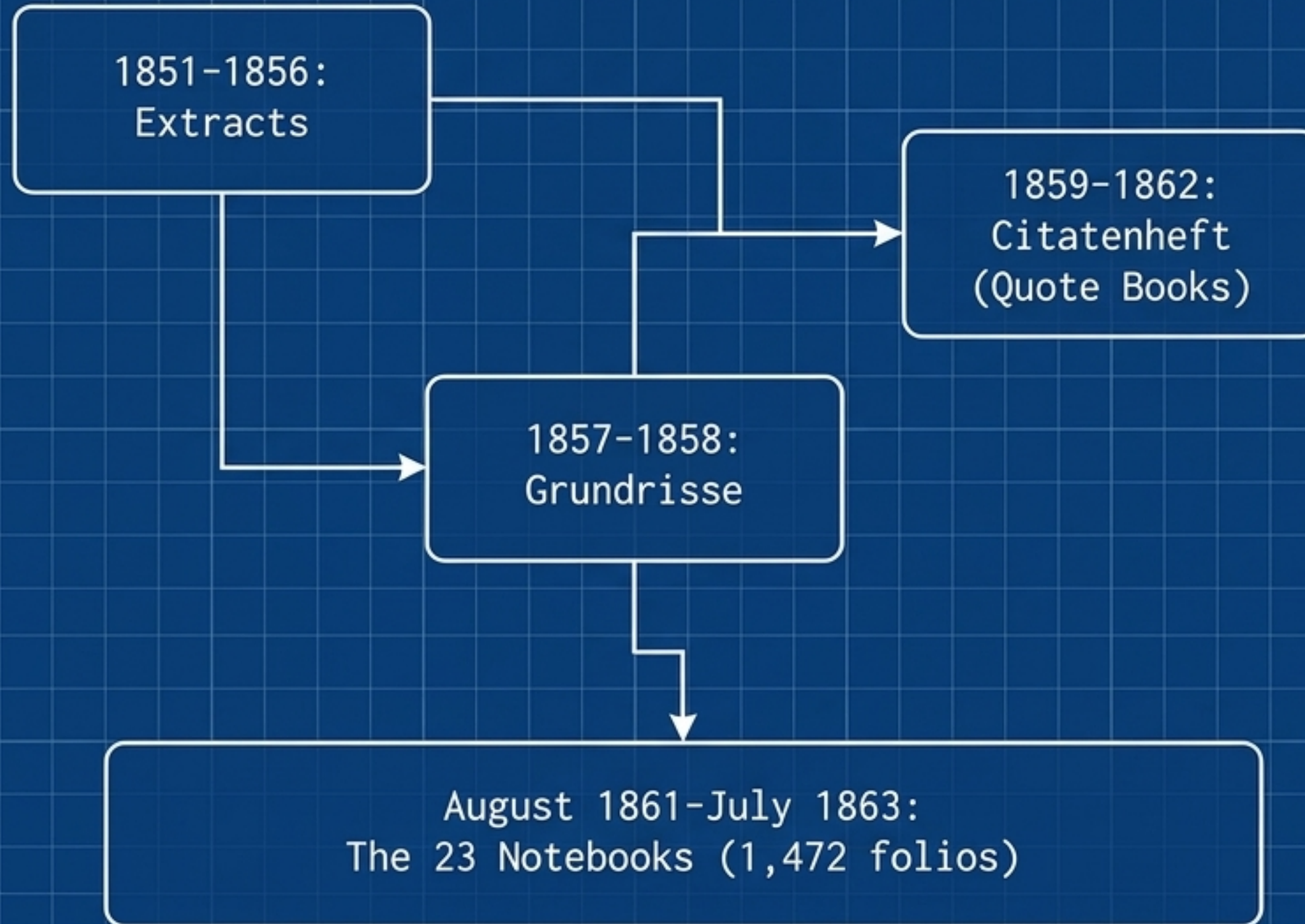


ANATOMY OF A TOTALITY

Enrique Dussel, the 1861-1863 Manuscripts,
and the Radical Exteriority of Marx

> "The concept of a thing and its reality run simultaneously like an asymptote: they always approach but never coincide." – Engels, 1895.

The Laboratory of Grafton Terrace



Between 1861 and 1863, Marx lived in near-destitution in London. His daily struggles with debt, illness, and isolation formed the backdrop for his most profound theoretical breakthroughs.

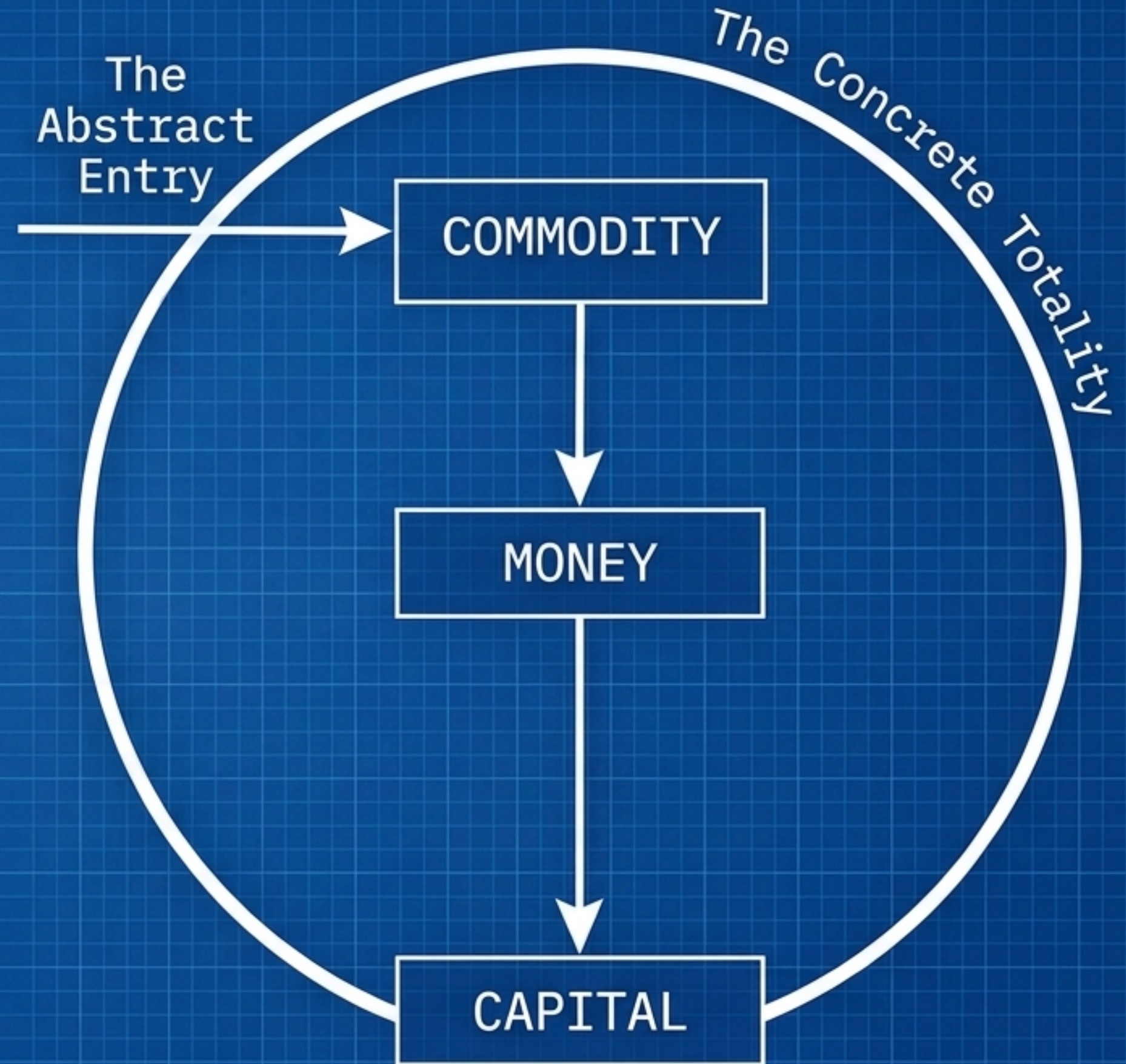
He treated his notebooks as a laboratory—testing, breaking, and building new economic categories to solve the mystery of Surplus Value.

"If we were animals, we could naturally turn our backs on the sufferings of humanity to look after our own skin. But I would have considered myself impractical if I had died without at least completing the manuscript of my book." – Marx, 1867.

The Dialectical Ascent: From Abstract to Concrete

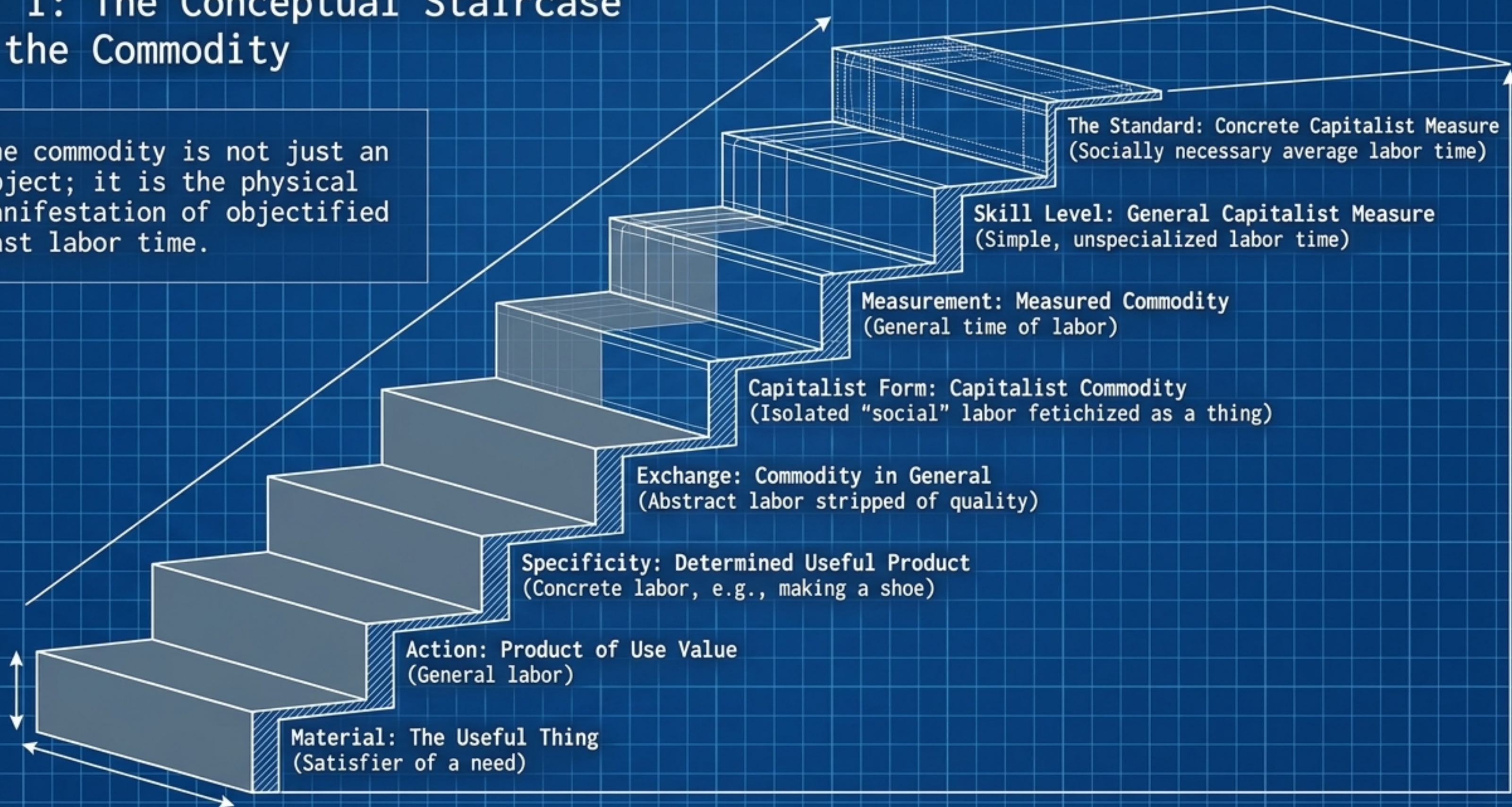
To critique political economy, Marx could not start with the complex reality of Capital. He had to enter the "hermeneutic circle" through the simplest, most abstract entity—the Commodity—and construct a categorical staircase upward.

1. **The Commodity** (Act I): The elemental "entity" of bourgeois wealth.
2. **Money** (Act I): The mediating force and universal equivalent.
3. **Capital** (Acts II & III): The concrete totality that consumes **living labor**.



ACT I: The Conceptual Staircase of the Commodity

The commodity is not just an object; it is the physical manifestation of objectified past labor time.

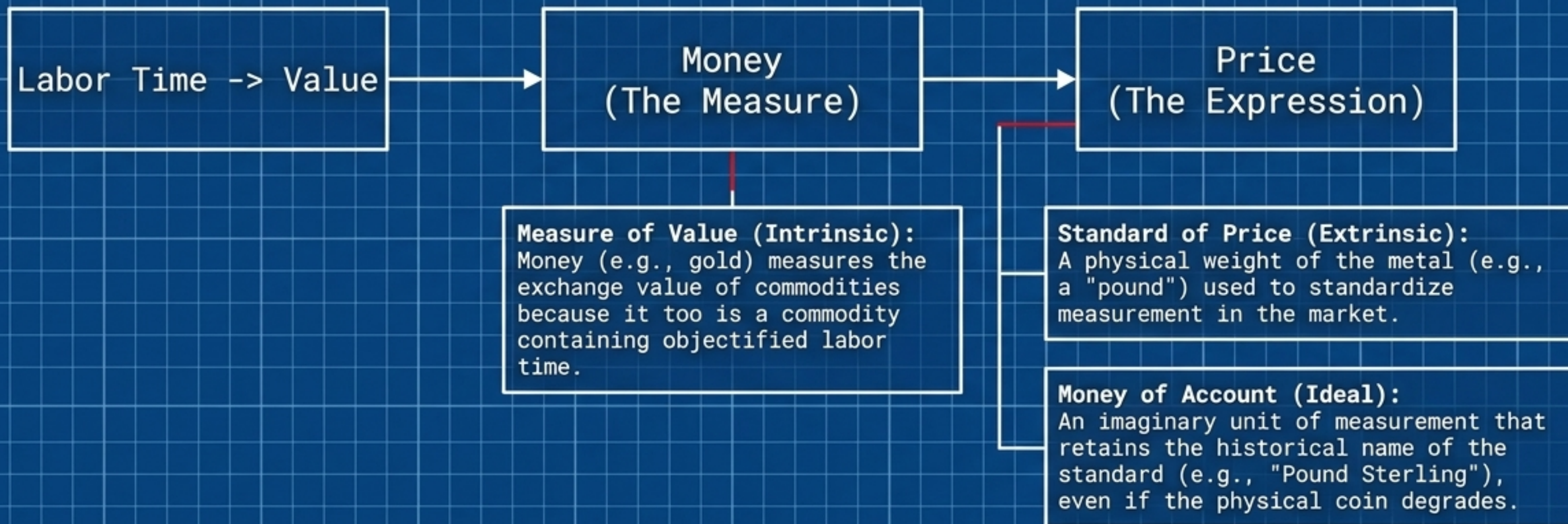


The Diagnostic Matrix of Economic Confusions

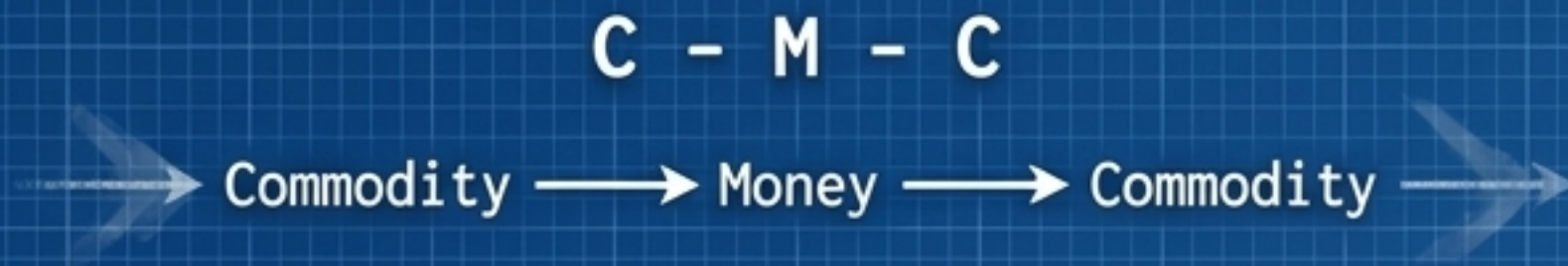
ECONOMIST	CORRECT INTUITION	THE CATEGORICAL "CONFUSION"
William Petty	Saw labor as the source of material wealth.	✗ Confused: Exchange Value with Money. Jumped directly from production to circulation without the mediating category of "Social Average Labor Time."
Benjamin Franklin	Linked money to labor.	✗ Confused: Concrete Labor with Social Labor. Failed to see the internal connection between abstract social labor and value.
Adam Smith	Saw time as a measure of value in production.	✗ Confused: Value of Commodity with "Value of Labor." Substituted the time of work for the price of the worker.
David Ricardo	Understood magnitude of value via labor time.	✗ Confused: Natural Labor with Capitalist Labor. Eternalized the bourgeois form of work, projecting it backward into natural history.

The Anatomy of Money

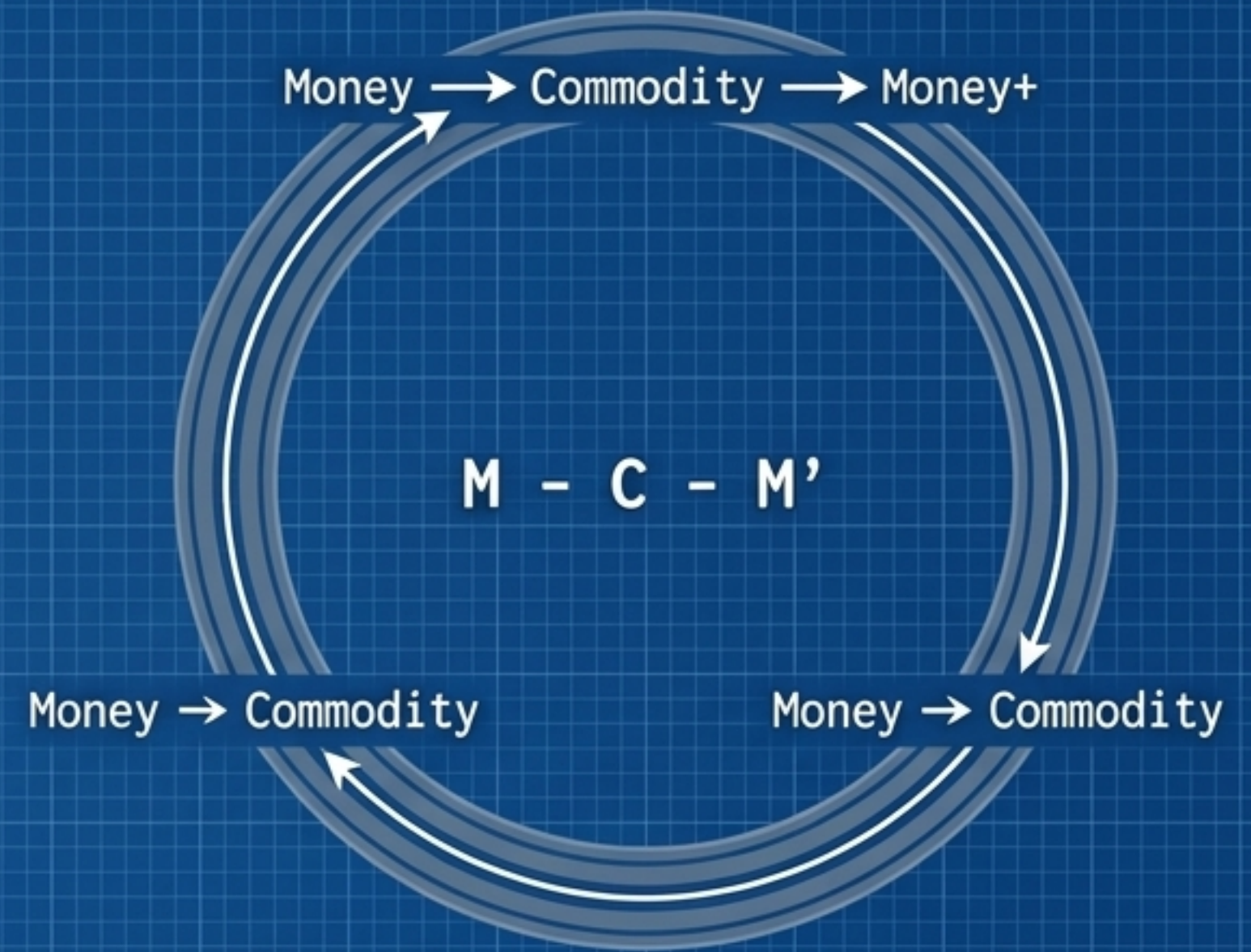
A commodity cannot directly measure its own exchange value. It requires a separated, universal equivalent—a second existence—to serve as the vehicle for exchange.



ACT II: The Totality of Capital



Simple Circulation (C-M-C): A seller exchanges a commodity for money to buy a different commodity for consumption. The goal is use value. The money stays in circulation.



Capitalist Totality (M-C-M'): The capitalist advances money to buy commodities, only to sell them for more money. The goal is the continuous, conscious expansion of exchange value.

The Core Mystery

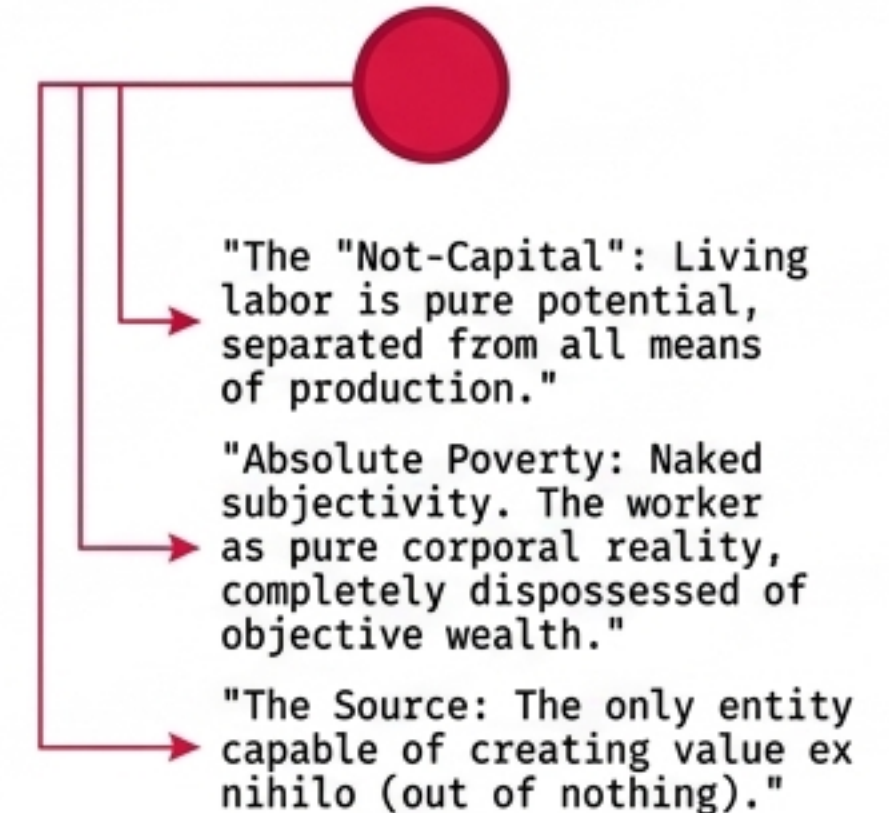
If commodities are exchanged at their true value, where does the extra value (+) at the end of the loop come from? Circulation alone cannot create value *ex nihilo*.

The Radical Exteriority of Living Labor

Enrique Dussel identifies Marx's ultimate metaphysical leap: Capital is a Totality of dead, objectified labor. It cannot grow on its own. The source of new value must come from outside the Totality.



EXTERIORITY



The Triad of Labor: Resolving the Confusion

Bourgeois economists failed because they conflated the human being with the capacity to work, and the capacity to work with the work itself. Marx split these concepts.

LIVING LABOR	CAPACITY FOR LABOR	OBJECTIFIED LABOR
Location: In the Exteriority. Nature: The living subject, pure activity, creator of value. Value: Has no value itself (cannot be priced or bought directly).	Location: On the boundary (The Commodity). Nature: The potential or dynamis to work. The physical/mental energy of the worker. Value: Has a price (the wage) equal to the cost of the sustenance needed to reproduce it.	Location: Inside the Totality. Nature: Dead labor, materialized in commodities and money. Value: Is the substance of value itself (Capital).

The Face-to-Face: The Ethical Encounter



The Worker (Subjectivity)

- Approaches the market with nothing but their own living corporality.
- Offers pure Capacity for Labor as a commodity.
- Driven by vital necessity to survive.



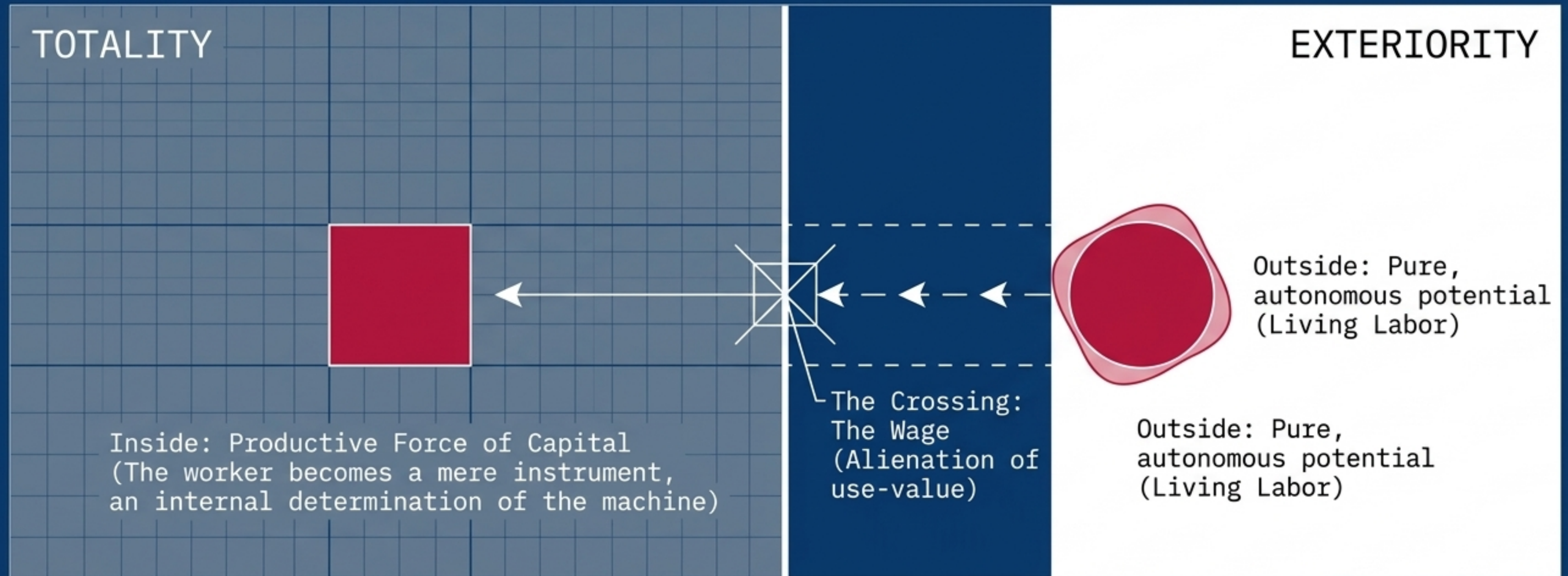
The Capitalist (Personified Value)

- Approaches the market as the conscious bearer of objectified past labor.
- Seeks to consume a specific use-value: the value-creating activity of the worker.
- Driven by the infinite drive for self-valorization.

"They confront each other as capital and labor, as capitalist and worker... One is in space, the other is in time; one is in the past, the other in the present." – Marx

ACT III: Subsumption and Alienation

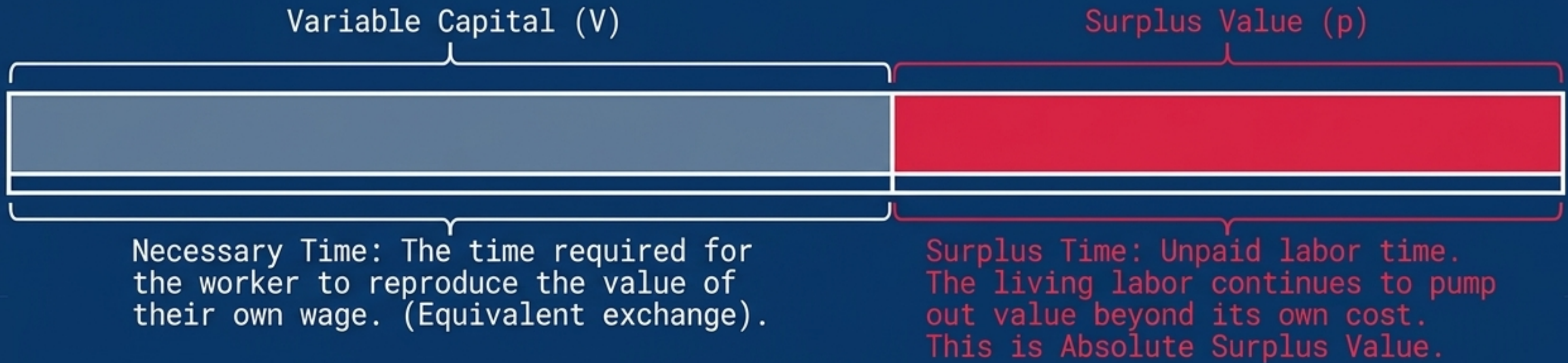
The wage contract is the moment of ontological transition. The capitalist buys the Capacity for Labor. Once purchased, the worker's living corporality is legally alienated and dragged into the Totality of capital.



The Engine of Surplus Value

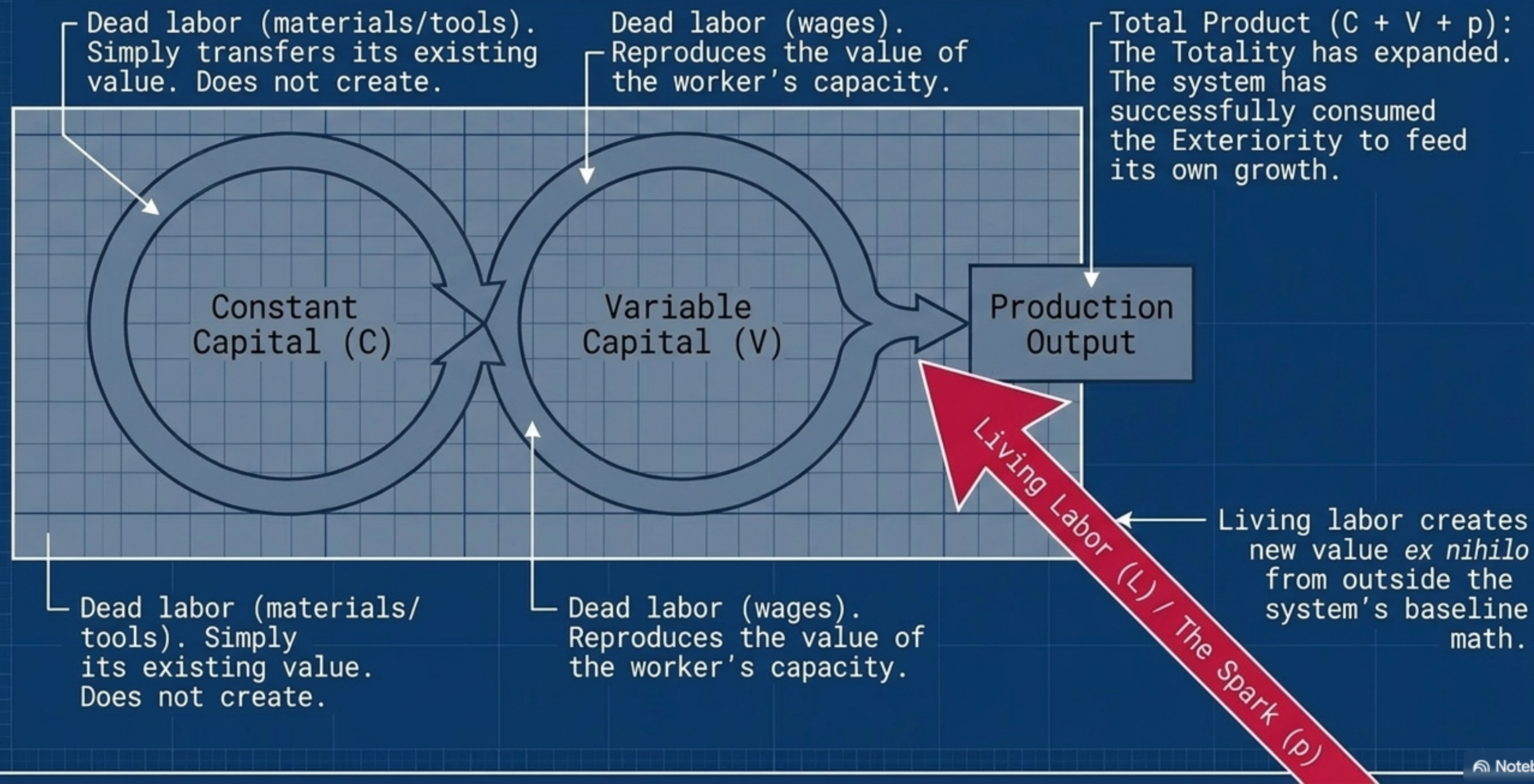
The capitalist pays the worker a wage equal to the cost of their survival (Variable Capital). But the capitalist consumes the worker's actual living labor for the entire day.

The Surplus Value Block Chart



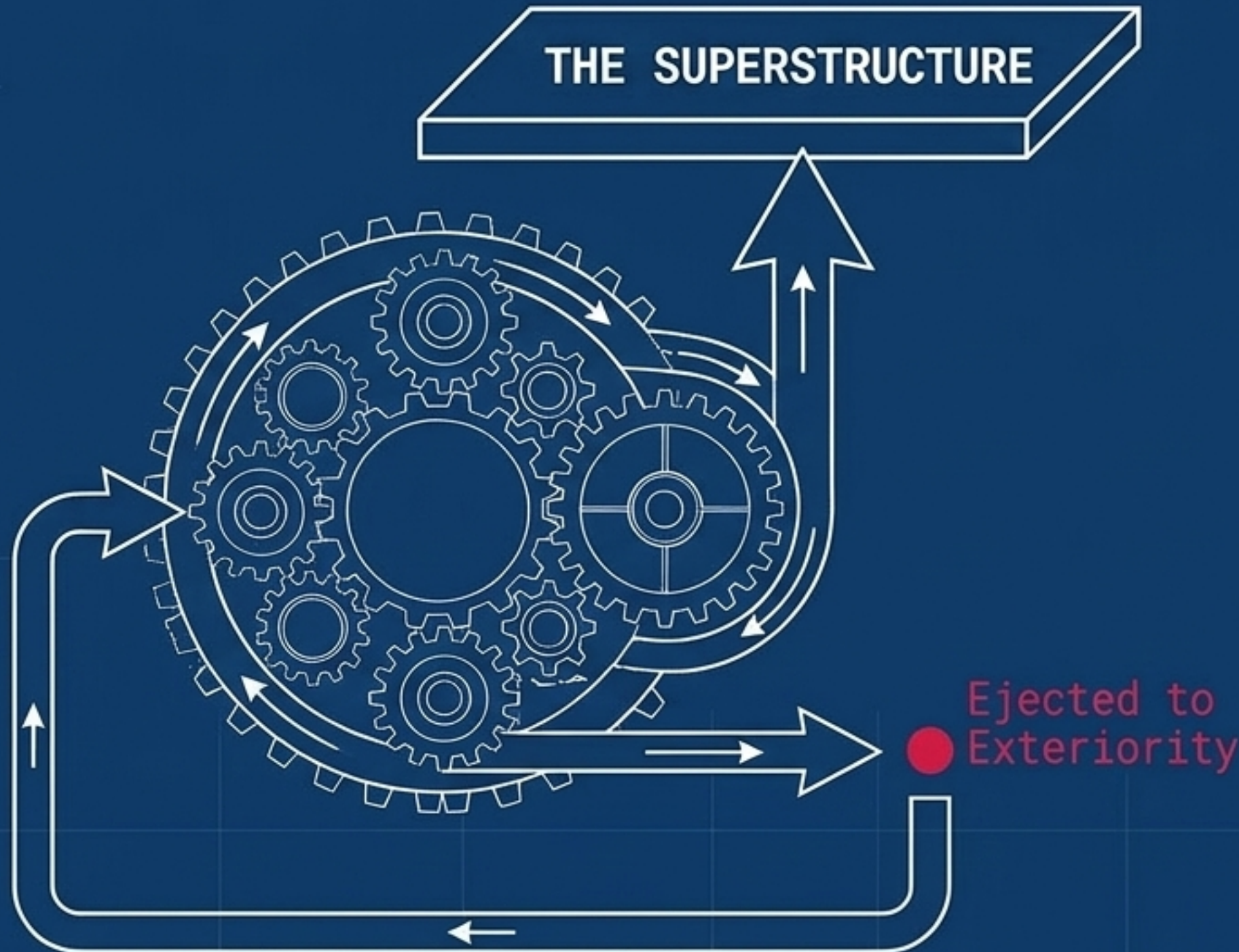
The wage pays for the capacity to work (the battery), but the capitalist gets the actual living labor (the electricity) for free during the surplus time.

The Anatomy of Capitalist Production



The Continuous Engine of Reproduction

The result of capitalist production is not just commodities and profit. It is the reproduction of the social relationship itself.



The Trap: The worker consumes their wage to survive, returning to the market the next day with nothing but their capacity to work, exactly as before.

The Superstructure: The surplus product extracted from the worker becomes the material base that funds the "free time" of non-working classes, the State, art, and science.

The Coercion: No external force is needed. The worker is bound by vital necessity to the very system that alienates them.

The Ethical Metaphysics of Marx

For Enrique Dussel, Marx's economic manuscripts are not merely a science of the Totality of capital. They are a profound "Philosophy of Liberation" rooted in the Exteriority of the human being.

- Capital is an ontology of the Same—a closed system of dead, objectified labor expanding infinitely.
- True reality, and the source of all value, lies outside this system in the living, breathing, suffering corporality of the worker.
- Marx's critique is ultimately an ethical defense of the absolute, transcendent dignity of Living Labor against its reduction to a mere internal gear of the machine.

EXTERIORITY